

broad,
muscular body

Peregrine falcon

Falco peregrinus

Renowned for its skill in the air, the peregrine chases down prey, rising above and diving, or rolling over underneath to grasp the bird in its claws. Its spectacular “stoop” is a long, angled dive with wings folded in a teardrop shape, reaching speeds of 125–150 mph (200–240 km/h). In level flight, while sometimes outflown by a desperate pigeon, the peregrine puts on a burst of speed that few birds can match.

Formidable hunter

Hunting success is around 50–60 percent, but peregrines often chase birds without attacking them. They catch birds up to the size of a pigeon, and occasionally ducks

and larger species. The decline of peregrines in the 1960s drew attention to the catastrophic effect of pesticides such as DDT, which is more concentrated further up the food chain. Birds of prey died or laid infertile or thin-shelled eggs. Peregrines have since recovered and often nest in towns, exploiting pigeon populations. They traditionally nested on cliffs, but high buildings are now used too.

tapered,
pointed wing

↔ 14–20 in (34–50 cm)

⚖ 1–3 lb (0.6–1.5 kg)

⊗ Common

🐦 Birds

🏠



Worldwide



△ BRACED TO LAND

Landing peregrines swoop upward to lose speed, spread their wings and tail as air brakes, then thrust out their feet to take the shock of landing and to grasp the perch.

◁ TINY PORTIONS

Like most birds of prey, peregrines bring freshly killed animals back to the nest. They tear off a small piece of food and delicately offer it to a chick.